GENERALIZED HERMITE–BIRKHOFF INTERPOLATION OF ARBITRARY ORDER IN ANY DIMENSION VIA SINGULAR-WEIGHT MOVING LEAST SQUARES

DAVID FIGUEIRAS GARCIA

Abstract. Singular-weight interpolating moving least squares (SWIMLS) reproduces function values at scattered nodes. We study the method when each node carries an arbitrary finite set of linear differential data $q(D)f(x_i)$. We prove that the interpolant is C^∞, give an exact representation of the error in every datum, and deduce that a datum is reproduced exactly if (i) every derivative of its symbol q lies in the span of the symbols prescribed at that node and (ii) $\Delta^{\alpha/2}q = 0$, where α is the (even) order of the weight singularity. Condition (ii) cannot be dropped. Whether condition (i) is needed depends on how the fit to the other nodes moves near x_i: we identify configurations in which it is not needed and give the first-order error otherwise. For classical Hermite data of order k, all data are reproduced if and only if $\alpha > k$ (the necessity under a mild condition on the other nodes), which proves a sharpened form of a conjecture of Komargodski and Levin. We also give exact counterexamples, in one and two dimensions, to their claim that derivatives prescribed at points without function values are interpolated, and a completion procedure that makes such data exact. A stable evaluator and experiments in one to three dimensions confirm the theory; in them the root-mean-square error decays like h^{m+1} for local degree m.

1. Introduction

Moving least squares (MLS) builds an approximant point by point: at each evaluation point x one fits a polynomial to the data by weighted least squares, with weights that decay away from x, and evaluates the fit at x. The method goes back to McLain [13, 14] and Lancaster and Šalkauskas [9]; its approximation theory is due to Levin [10] and Wendland [22], see also [5]. When the weights are singular at the nodes, $w_i(x) = |x - x_i|^{-\alpha}$, the approximant interpolates the data [9]; with constant local polynomials it is Shepard's method [21]. Interpolating MLS needs no mesh and no global linear system, and it is local, smooth and exact on polynomials of the local degree; MLS is also optimal in the sense of Backus and Gilbert [2], and nearly interpolating weights are used to impose boundary conditions in meshless methods [16].

In many applications the data include derivatives: slopes and curvatures in curve and surface design, gradients in derivative-enhanced surrogate models, fluxes and normal derivatives in meshless discretisations of differential equations. Kernel methods handle such Hermite–Birkhoff data by building the derivatives into the kernel matrix [23, 17], at the price of a global system. In meshless methods, derivative data have been built into MLS fits [1], and generalized MLS approximates derivatives and other functionals from values [15]. For interpolating MLS, Komargodski and Levin [8] proposed using the same singular weights for value and derivative data at a node. They proved that this interpolates values and first derivatives in one dimension, and reported that for data up to second derivatives $\alpha = 2$ is not enough while $\alpha = 4$ works. They conjectured that $\alpha = 2k$ suffices for derivatives up to order k, and stated that the method also interpolates directional derivatives prescribed at points that carry no function value.

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Polynomial Hermite–Birkhoff interpolation in several variables is notoriously delicate: whether a data pattern is poised depends on the pattern and on the geometry of the nodes [12, 7, 11]; the natural class of local data is that of D-invariant spaces, which characterise ideal interpolation [4, 18]; see also [3, 20]. Interpolating MLS avoids the global poisedness question, since it only asks that the data be unisolvent on the local polynomial space. It replaces it by a local question: which data are reproduced? This paper answers that question.

We call the method SWIMLS (singular-weight interpolating moving least squares) and analyse it for arbitrary finite sets of linear differential data $q(D)f(x_i)$ at each node, in any dimension. The analysis rests on two elementary tools, the Fischer pairing of a symbol with a polynomial and a structure theorem for the local fit near a node, and it leads to an exact formula for the error in each datum.

Contributions.

(1) A structure theorem for SWIMLS near a node (Theorem 4.1): the interpolant is C^∞, and an exact representation of the error in any differential datum (Theorem 4.3).
(2) A sufficient condition for exact reproduction of a datum $q(D)f(x_i)$: closure of the symbol under differentiation and $\Delta^{\alpha/2}q = 0$ (Corollary 4.4). The second condition cannot be dropped: it is necessary at leading order (Proposition 4.6).
(3) The role of the first condition: it is not needed when the minimiser of the "frozen" problem at the other nodes does not move near x_i (Theorem 4.8), e.g. for a single other node or locally proportional weights; in general its failure produces the explicit first-order error of Proposition 4.11.
(4) For classical Hermite data of order k: all data are reproduced when $\alpha > k$, and this is sharp (Corollaries 4.5 and 4.7); when $\alpha \le k$ the error is the linear functional $q \mapsto \big[\Delta^{\alpha/2}q, \tau\big]_{x_i}$ of the datum. This proves, for $k \ge 3$ in a sharper form, the conjecture of [8, §3] that $\alpha = 2k$ suffices.
(5) Exact counterexamples in one and two dimensions to the extension claimed in [8, §3] (Propositions 5.1 and 5.2), and a completion procedure that makes data with gaps exact (Proposition 5.3).
(6) A numerically stable evaluation of SWIMLS, including the closed-form limit at the nodes, and numerical experiments in one, two and three dimensions.

Outline. Section 2 shows the method and both failure mechanisms on a one-dimensional example. Section 3 fixes notation, Section 4 contains the theory, and Section 5 treats derivatives at points without values. Sections 6 and 7 describe the evaluator and the experiments, and Section 8 lists open problems.

2. A one-dimensional example

Take the nodes $x_i = i$, $i = 0, 1, 2, 3$, prescribe values f_i and slopes f_i', and fix the exponent $\alpha = 2$. At every point x that is not a node, let p_x be the quadratic polynomial that minimises

$$J_x(p) = \sum_{i=0}^{3} \frac{\big(p(x_i) - f_i\big)^2 + \big(p'(x_i) - f_i'\big)^2}{(x - x_i)^2}, \tag{1}$$

and set $u(x) := p_x(x)$. The minimiser is linear in the data, so $u = \sum_i \big(f_i\varphi_i + f_i'\psi_i\big)$ with shape functions φ_i, ψ_i; two of them are shown in Figure 1(a). They have the cardinal property of Hermite interpolation: $\varphi_i(x_j) = \delta_{ij}$, $\varphi_i'(x_j) = 0$, $\psi_i(x_j) = 0$ and $\psi_i'(x_j) = \delta_{ij}$. Nothing in (1) uses the ordering of the nodes or a mesh, and the same definition works with any number of nodes in any dimension.

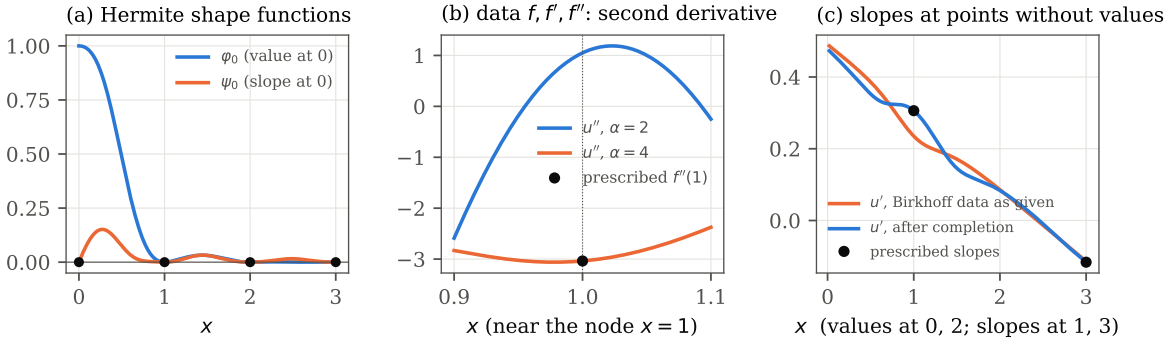


FIGURE 1. The one-dimensional example. (a) Shape functions for the value and the slope at $x = 0$ (nodes $0, 1, 2, 3$, $m = 2$, $\alpha = 2$). (b) Data f, f', f'' at the nodes: u'' near the node $x = 1$ for $\alpha = 2$ and $\alpha = 4$; only $\alpha = 4$ reproduces $f''(1)$ (Corollary 4.5). (c) Values at $0, 2$ and slopes at $1, 3$: the slopes are not reproduced (Proposition 5.1) until the data are completed (Proposition 5.3).

Why are the slopes reproduced? Near the node $x_1 = 1$, multiply (1) by $(x-1)^2$. The first term becomes $(p(1) - f_1)^2 + (p'(1) - f_1')^2$ and the others are multiplied by the small factor $t = (x-1)^2$. Write the quadratic as $p = p^* + r + c\,(y-1)^2$, where p^* is the line with value f_1 and slope f_1' at 1 and r is a linear polynomial: the node data see r but not c. Balancing the two parts of the functional gives $r = O(t)$, while c is determined by the other nodes. Section 4 makes this precise:

$$p_x(y) = p^*(y) + \nu(x)\,(y-1)^2 + (x-1)^2\,\sigma(x)(y),$$

with smooth coefficients ν and σ. At $y = x$ both correction terms vanish to second order at $x = 1$, so $u(1) = f_1$ and $u'(1) = f_1'$.

The same picture explains what can go wrong. If we also prescribe second derivatives and use local cubics, the correction $(x-1)^2\sigma(x)(x)$ contributes $2\sigma(1)(1)$ to $u''(1)$, and the datum $f''(1)$ is missed (Figure 1(b): $u''(1) = 1.05$ against $f''(1) = -3.04$). With $\alpha = 4$ the correction is $(x-1)^4\sigma(x)(x)$, which does not affect the second derivative, and $f''(1)$ is reproduced. This is the rule "α larger than the order of the data" of Corollary 4.5.

The other failure concerns gaps in the data. Prescribe values at 0 and 2 and slopes at 1 and 3 (Figure 1(c)). At $x_1 = 1$ the only datum, the slope, does not see constants. The constant term $\nu_0(x)$ of p_x is then chosen by the other nodes, it varies with x, and its derivative $\nu_0'(1)$ adds to $u'(1)$. The prescribed slope 0.306 comes out as 0.235. Adding an estimate of the missing values $f(1)$ and $f(3)$ to the data, by any method, restores exactness (Proposition 5.3); the slopes are then reproduced to the accuracy of finite differences.

3. Setting and notation

3.1. **Polynomials, symbols and the Fischer pairing.** For $d \geq 1$ and $m \geq 0$ let $\Pi_m = \Pi_m(\mathbb{R}^d)$ be the real polynomials of total degree at most m. Multi-indices are $\beta \in \mathbb{N}_0^d$, with $|\beta| = \sum_j \beta_j$, $\beta! = \prod_j \beta_j!$, $D^\beta = \partial^{|\beta|}/\partial x_1^{\beta_1} \cdots \partial x_d^{\beta_d}$. A polynomial $q(\xi) = \sum_\beta q_\beta \xi^\beta$, called a *symbol*, defines the differential operator $q(D) = \sum_\beta q_\beta D^\beta$. We write $\partial^\gamma q$ for derivatives of a symbol with respect to ξ, and $\Delta q = \sum_j \partial_j^2 q$.

For a symbol q, a smooth function g and a point z we set

$$[q, g]_z := \big(q(D)g\big)(z), \qquad [q, g] := [q, g]_0. \tag{2}$$

For polynomials q, p, $\big[q,p\big] = \sum_\beta \beta!\, q_\beta p_\beta$ is the *Fischer inner product* [6, 19]; it is positive definite on Π_m. Four elementary facts will be used.

Lemma 3.1 (Fischer adjointness)**.** *For symbols q and polynomials p, $\big[q, z_j p\big] = \big[\partial_j q, p\big]$. Consequently $\big[q, |z|^{2\ell} p\big] = \big[\Delta^\ell q, p\big]$ for every $\ell \in \mathbb{N}_0$, where $|z|^2 = \sum_j z_j^2$.*

Proof. With e_j the j-th unit multi-index, $\big[q, z_j p\big] = \sum_\kappa \kappa!\, q_\kappa p_{\kappa - e_j} = \sum_\lambda (\lambda + e_j)!\, q_{\lambda+e_j} p_\lambda = \sum_\lambda \lambda!\, (\lambda_j + 1) q_{\lambda+e_j} p_\lambda = \big[\partial_j q, p\big]$. Multiplication by $|z|^2 = \sum_j z_j \cdot z_j$ is therefore adjoint to $\sum_j \partial_j^2 = \Delta$, and the second statement follows by induction. □

Lemma 3.2 (Taylor expansion of operators)**.** *Let $A = (A_1, \dots, A_d)$ and $B = (B_1, \dots, B_d)$ be commuting operators. For every symbol q, $q(A + B) = \sum_\gamma \frac{1}{\gamma!} A^\gamma (\partial^\gamma q)(B)$ (a finite sum).*

Proof. This is Taylor's formula $q(a + b) = \sum_\gamma \frac{a^\gamma}{\gamma!} (\partial^\gamma q)(b)$ for the polynomial q, an identity in the commutative polynomial ring in a, b. □

Lemma 3.3. *Let $\ell \in \mathbb{N}_0$ and $\beta \in \mathbb{N}_0^d$. Then $\Delta^\ell \xi^\beta = 0$ if and only if $\sum_j \lfloor \beta_j/2 \rfloor < \ell$.*

Proof. By the multinomial formula, $\Delta^\ell \xi^\beta = \sum_{|\kappa| = \ell} \frac{\ell!}{\kappa!}\, \partial^{2\kappa} \xi^\beta$, and $\partial^{2\kappa} \xi^\beta = \frac{\beta!}{(\beta - 2\kappa)!} \xi^{\beta - 2\kappa}$ if $2\kappa \le \beta$ and 0 otherwise. Distinct κ give distinct monomials and all coefficients are positive, so $\Delta^\ell \xi^\beta \neq 0$ if and only if some κ with $|\kappa| = \ell$ satisfies $2\kappa \le \beta$, i.e. $\sum_j \lfloor \beta_j/2 \rfloor \ge \ell$. □

Lemma 3.4. *Let $\alpha \in 2\mathbb{N}$. Then $\sum_{|\gamma| = \alpha} \frac{1}{\gamma!} \big(D^\gamma |x|^\alpha\big)(0)\, \partial^\gamma = \Delta^{\alpha/2}$ as operators on symbols.*

Proof. $|x|^\alpha = \sum_{|\kappa| = \alpha/2} \frac{(\alpha/2)!}{\kappa!} x^{2\kappa}$, and $(D^\gamma x^{2\kappa})(0) = (2\kappa)!$ if $\gamma = 2\kappa$ and 0 otherwise. Hence the left side equals $\sum_{|\kappa| = \alpha/2} \frac{(\alpha/2)!}{\kappa!} \partial^{2\kappa} = \big(\sum_j \partial_j^2\big)^{\alpha/2}$. □

3.2. **Data.** Let $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^d$ be open and $X = \{x_1, \dots, x_K\} \subset \Omega$ distinct nodes. Node x_i carries symbols $q_{i,1}, \dots, q_{i,n_i}$ of degree at most m and values $y_{i,1}, \dots, y_{i,n_i} \in \mathbb{R}$, i.e. the interpolation conditions

$$\lambda_{i,s}(f) := \big[q_{i,s}, f\big]_{x_i} = \big(q_{i,s}(D) f\big)(x_i) = y_{i,s}, \qquad s = 1, \dots, n_i,\ i = 1, \dots, K. \tag{3}$$

We write $Q_i = \operatorname{span}\{q_{i,1}, \dots, q_{i,n_i}\}$ for the space of symbols at x_i. Every $q = \sum_s c_s q_{i,s} \in Q_i$ has a prescribed value $y_q := \sum_s c_s y_{i,s}$; we say that the datum q is *reproduced* by a function u if $\big[q, u\big]_{x_i} = y_q$. Classical Hermite data of order k correspond to $Q_i = \operatorname{span}\{\xi^\beta : |\beta| \le k\}$; any other choice will be called Hermite–Birkhoff data. A space of symbols is *D-invariant* if it is closed under differentiation.

Assumption 3.5.
- (A1) $\alpha \in 2\mathbb{N}$ is even, and $w_i(x) = \rho_i(x)\, |x - x_i|^{-\alpha}$ with $\rho_i \in C^\infty(\Omega)$, $\rho_i > 0$.
- (A2) For every i the symbols $q_{i,1}, \dots, q_{i,n_i}$ are linearly independent.
- (A3) (Unisolvency) If $p \in \Pi_m$ and $\lambda_{i,s}(p) = 0$ for all i, s, then $p = 0$.

Since $\big[\cdot, \cdot\big]_{x_i}$ is non-degenerate on Π_m (it is the Fischer pairing after translation) and $\deg q_{i,s} \le m$, (A2) is equivalent to the linear independence of the functionals $\lambda_{i,1}, \dots, \lambda_{i,n_i}$ on Π_m.

Definition 3.6 (SWIMLS)**.** For $x \in \Omega \setminus X$ let

$$J_x(p) = \sum_{i=1}^{K} w_i(x) \sum_{s=1}^{n_i} \big(\lambda_{i,s}(p) - y_{i,s}\big)^2, \qquad p_x := \operatorname*{arg\,min}_{p \in \Pi_m} J_x(p), \tag{4}$$

and define the interpolant $u(x) := p_x(x)$.

By (A1) and (A3), J_x is a strictly convex quadratic on Π_m for every $x \notin X$, so p_x is unique; it depends smoothly on $x \in \Omega \setminus X$ because the coefficients of J_x do and its Hessian is positive definite. Hence $u \in C^\infty(\Omega \setminus X)$. The behaviour at the nodes is the subject of the next section.

Remark 3.7. Positive smooth factors for the individual functionals of a node can be included: the first block of the Jacobian in the proof of Theorem 4.1 becomes $2L^*W(x)L$, still invertible, and nothing else changes. If some functionals at x_i are *not* given the singular factor, they must be moved from Q_i to the regular part B_x of the proof, and Q_i, N_i refer to the singular ones only.

4. Main results

Throughout this section we fix a node x_i and write

$$N_i = \{p \in \Pi_m : \lambda_{i,s}(p) = 0,\ s = 1, \dots, n_i\} = \{p \in \Pi_m : \big[q, p\big]_{x_i} = 0\ \forall q \in Q_i\}$$

for the polynomials that the data at x_i do not see.

4.1. **Structure near a node.**

Theorem 4.1 (Structure near a node)**.** *Let Assumption 3.5 hold, fix an inner product on Π_m and let $R = N_i^\perp$. There are an open neighbourhood $U \subset \Omega$ of x_i with $U \cap X = \{x_i\}$, a polynomial $p_i^* \in R$ with $\lambda_{i,s}(p_i^*) = y_{i,s}$ for all s, and C^∞ maps $\nu : U \to N_i$ and $\sigma : U \to R$ such that*

$$p_x = p_i^* + \nu(x) + |x - x_i|^\alpha\, \sigma(x) \qquad \text{for all } x \in U \setminus \{x_i\}. \tag{5}$$

More precisely, $\nu(x) = n(x, |x-x_i|^\alpha)$ and $\sigma(x) = s(x, |x-x_i|^\alpha)$ for C^∞ maps n, s defined near $(x_i, 0)$, and $Z(x) := n(x, 0)$ is the frozen minimiser

$$Z(x) = \operatorname*{arg\,min}_{n \in N_i}\ B_x(p_i^* + n), \qquad B_x(p) := \sum_{j \neq i} \frac{w_j(x)}{\rho_i(x)} \sum_{s=1}^{n_j} \big(\lambda_{j,s}(p) - y_{j,s}\big)^2. \tag{6}$$

Applying this at every node, u extends to a function in $C^\infty(\Omega)$, with node value $u(x_i) = \big(p_i^* + Z(x_i)\big)(x_i)$.

Proof. Write $\Lambda_i : \Pi_m \to \mathbb{R}^{n_i}$, $p \mapsto (\lambda_{i,s}(p))_s$, and Λ_j likewise. By (A2) Λ_i is surjective with kernel N_i, so $L := \Lambda_i|_R : R \to \mathbb{R}^{n_i}$ is bijective; put $p_i^* := L^{-1} y_i \in R$. Every $p \in \Pi_m$ is uniquely $p = p_i^* + r + n$ with $r \in R$, $n \in N_i$, and then $\Lambda_i p - y_i = Lr$.

Let U be an open neighbourhood of x_i containing no other node. For $x \in U \setminus \{x_i\}$ divide J_x by $w_i(x) > 0$:

$$\frac{J_x(p)}{w_i(x)} = |Lr|^2 + t(x)\, B_x(p), \qquad t(x) := |x - x_i|^\alpha,$$

with B_x as in (6). Since α is even, $t(x) = \big(\sum_k (x_k - x_{i,k})^2\big)^{\alpha/2}$ is a polynomial in x; and $x \mapsto B_x$ is a C^∞ family of convex quadratics on U, because $\rho_i > 0$ and the w_j, $j \neq i$, are smooth on U. A polynomial $p = p_i^* + r + n$ minimises J_x if and only if the gradient vanishes (the problem is convex), that is

$$2L^*Lr + t(x) \nabla_R B_x(p) = 0, \qquad t(x) \nabla_N B_x(p) = 0,$$

where ∇_R, ∇_N denote the components of the gradient in R and N_i and L^* is the adjoint of L. Since $t(x) > 0$ for $x \neq x_i$ we may substitute $r = t(x)\, s$ and divide by $t(x)$, obtaining $F(x, t(x); s, n) = 0$ for the map $F : U \times \mathbb{R} \times R \times N_i \to R \times N_i$,

$$F(x, t; s, n) := \Big(2L^*Ls + \nabla_R B_x(p_i^* + ts + n),\ \nabla_N B_x(p_i^* + ts + n)\Big),$$

which is C^∞ in all variables, including t near 0.

The point $(x_i, 0)$. Here $F = 0$ reads $\nabla_N B_{x_i}(p_i^* + n) = 0$ and $s = -(2L^*L)^{-1}\nabla_R B_{x_i}(p_i^* + n)$. The restriction of B_x to the affine space $p_i^* + N_i$ is strictly convex for every $x \in U$: its Hessian is $2\sum_{j\neq i} \frac{w_j(x)}{\rho_i(x)}\Lambda_j^*\Lambda_j$ restricted to N_i, with $w_j(x) > 0$ since $x \neq x_j$; and if $n \in N_i$ satisfies $\Lambda_j n = 0$ for all $j \neq i$ then all data functionals vanish on n, so $n = 0$ by (A3). Hence there is exactly one solution (s_0, n_0), and $n_0 = Z(x_i)$; more generally, for every $x \in U$ the equation $F(x, 0; s, n) = 0$ has the unique solution $n = Z(x)$, $s = -(2L^*L)^{-1}\nabla_R B_x(p_i^* + Z(x))$.

Implicit function theorem. At $(x_i, 0; s_0, n_0)$ the derivative of F with respect to (s, n) is block triangular,

$$\frac{\partial F}{\partial(s,n)} = \begin{pmatrix} 2L^*L & \left(\nabla^2 B_{x_i}\right)_{RN} \\ 0 & \left(\nabla^2 B_{x_i}\right)_{NN} \end{pmatrix},$$

because every derivative with respect to s of a B-term carries the factor $t = 0$. Both diagonal blocks are invertible (L is injective; the second block is the Hessian above). By the implicit function theorem there are a neighbourhood $U' \times (-\tau_0, \tau_0)$ of $(x_i, 0)$ and a C^∞ map $(x, t) \mapsto (s(x,t), n(x,t))$ with $F(x, t; s(x,t), n(x,t)) = 0$; by the uniqueness just shown, $n(x, 0) = Z(x)$. Shrinking U to $U' \cap \{t(x) < \tau_0\}$, for $x \in U \setminus \{x_i\}$ the polynomial $p_i^* + t(x)s(x, t(x)) + n(x, t(x))$ satisfies the gradient equations of the strictly convex function J_x, hence it equals p_x (only uniqueness of the critical point of J_x is used). Setting $\nu(x) := n(x, t(x)) \in N_i$ and $\sigma(x) := s(x, t(x)) \in R$ gives (5); both maps are C^∞ because t is a polynomial. Finally $u(x) = p_x(x)$ is, by (5), the restriction to $U \setminus \{x_i\}$ of the C^∞ function $x \mapsto (p_i^* + \nu(x) + t(x)\sigma(x))(x)$, whose value at x_i is $(p_i^* + Z(x_i))(x_i)$. □

Remark 4.2. The decomposition (5) is canonical up to the choice of the complement R of N_i; the node value $u(x_i)$ and all errors below do not depend on it. Evenness of α is used twice: to make $t(x) = |x - x_i|^\alpha$ smooth at x_i (Theorem 4.1) and to make it a polynomial, so that Lemmas 3.1 and 3.4 apply (Theorems 4.3 and 4.8). If the ρ_i are real analytic, the analytic implicit function theorem shows that u is real analytic. For odd α the function t is not smooth at x_i, our arguments do not apply, and we do not consider this case.

4.2. **An exact error representation.**

Theorem 4.3 (Error representation)**.** *With the notation of Theorem 4.1, let* $\tau(z) := \sigma(z)(z)$ *for* $z \in U$ *(a* C^∞ *scalar function). For every symbol* q*,*

$$[q, u]_{x_i} = [q, p_i^*]_{x_i} + \sum_\gamma \frac{1}{\gamma!} D^\gamma \Big[x \mapsto [\partial^\gamma q, \nu(x)]_{x_i}\Big](x_i) + [\Delta^{\alpha/2} q, \tau]_{x_i}. \tag{7}$$

The $\gamma = 0$ *term of the middle sum is* $[q, \nu(x_i)]_{x_i}$.

Proof. On $U \times \mathbb{R}^d$ consider the C^∞ function $\Phi(x, y) = p_i^*(y) + \nu(x)(y) + t(x)\,\sigma(x)(y) =: \Phi_1 + \Phi_2 + \Phi_3$, which is a polynomial in y and satisfies $u(z) = \Phi(z, z)$ for all $z \in U$, including $z = x_i$ by the definition of the extension. By the chain rule along the diagonal, $D_z^\beta[\Phi(z,z)] = \big[(D_x + D_y)^\beta \Phi\big](z, z)$, hence $[q, u]_{x_i} = \big[q(D_x + D_y)\Phi\big](x_i, x_i)$. We treat the three parts.

Φ_1 does not depend on x, so it contributes $(q(D)p_i^*)(x_i) = [q, p_i^*]_{x_i}$.

For Φ_2, Lemma 3.2 with $A = D_x$, $B = D_y$ gives $q(D_x + D_y)\Phi_2 = \sum_\gamma \frac{1}{\gamma!} D_x^\gamma\,(\partial^\gamma q)(D_y)\Phi_2$. Setting $y = x_i$ commutes with D_x, and $\big((\partial^\gamma q)(D_y)\Phi_2\big)(x, x_i) = [\partial^\gamma q, \nu(x)]_{x_i}$; setting $x = x_i$ gives the middle term of (7).

For Φ_3 we use the diagonal again: its contribution is $[q, t\,\tau]_{x_i} = \big(q(D)[\,|z - x_i|^\alpha \tau(z)]\big)(x_i)$. Translate x_i to 0 and let $T\tau$ be the Taylor polynomial of τ at 0 of degree $\deg q$. Since $|z|^\alpha(\tau - T\tau)$

vanishes at 0 to order larger than $\deg q$, it is annihilated by $q(D)$ at 0, and by Lemma 3.1

$$\big[q, |z|^\alpha \tau\big] = \big[q, |z|^\alpha T\tau\big] = \big[\Delta^{\alpha/2} q, T\tau\big] = \big[\Delta^{\alpha/2} q, \tau\big],$$

the last equality because $\deg \Delta^{\alpha/2} q \le \deg q - \alpha \le \deg T\tau$. □

4.3. **Exact reproduction.**

Corollary 4.4 (Sufficient condition)**.** *Let Assumption 3.5 hold and let $q \in Q_i$. If*

(i) $\partial^\gamma q \in Q_i$ for every multi-index γ, and

(ii) $\Delta^{\alpha/2} q = 0$,

then the datum q is reproduced: $\big[q, u\big]_{x_i} = y_q$. If Q_i is D-invariant, the error is the linear functional

$$\big[q, u\big]_{x_i} - y_q = \big[\Delta^{\alpha/2} q, \tau\big]_{x_i}, \qquad q \in Q_i. \tag{8}$$

Proof. In (7), $\big[q, p_i^*\big]_{x_i} = \sum_s c_s \lambda_{i,s}(p_i^*) = y_q$. By (i), every $\partial^\gamma q$ (including $\gamma = 0$) lies in Q_i, and $\nu(x) \in N_i$, so $\big[\partial^\gamma q, \nu(x)\big]_{x_i} = 0$ for all $x \in U$: the middle term vanishes. This proves (8) when Q_i is D-invariant, and the last term vanishes by (ii). □

Condition (i) concerns the datum and the data at its own node only; it holds for every datum when Q_i is D-invariant, the classical setting of multivariate Hermite interpolation [18, 3]. Condition (ii) holds whenever $\deg q < \alpha$, but also, for instance, for every harmonic symbol when $\alpha = 2$. By (8) the reproduced data at a D-invariant node form the subspace $\{q \in Q_i : \Delta^{\alpha/2} q = 0\}$ plus the kernel of the functional $\big[\cdot, \tau\big]_{x_i}$ on $\Delta^{\alpha/2} Q_i$; for instance, at $\alpha = 2$ the errors in $\partial_x^2 f$ and $\partial_y^2 f$ coincide, $\partial_x^2 - \partial_y^2$ is reproduced, and the error in $\partial_x^3 f$ is three times that in $\partial_x \partial_y^2 f$.

Corollary 4.5 (Hermite data)**.** *Let x_i carry classical Hermite data of order $k \le m$, i.e. $Q_i = \operatorname{span}\{\xi^\beta : |\beta| \le k\}$. Then every $q \in Q_i$ with $\Delta^{\alpha/2} q = 0$ is reproduced. In particular:*

(a) the derivative datum $D^\beta f(x_i)$ is reproduced whenever $\sum_j \lfloor \beta_j/2 \rfloor < \alpha/2$;

(b) all data at x_i are reproduced if $\alpha > k$, i.e. for $\alpha = k+1$ when k is odd and $\alpha = k+2$ when k is even;

(c) for $\alpha = 2$ the monomial data covered by (a) are exactly the multilinear ones ($\beta_j \le 1$ for all j, e.g. $\partial_x \partial_y$, $\partial_x \partial_y \partial_z$), whatever their order.

Proof. Q_i is D-invariant, so Corollary 4.4 applies; (a) and (c) are Lemma 3.3 with $\ell = \alpha/2$, and (b) follows from $\deg q \le k < \alpha$. □

Corollary 4.5(b) proves the conjecture of [8, §3] that $\alpha = 2k$ suffices for data up to order k (they also observed that $\alpha = 2$ fails and $\alpha = 4$ works for $k = 2$); for $k \ge 3$ it is a strict improvement, e.g. $\alpha = 4$ suffices for $k = 3$. The next result shows that condition (ii) cannot be dropped, and with it that (b) is sharp (Corollary 4.7).

Proposition 4.6 (Necessity of (ii), leading order)**.** *In addition to Assumption 3.5, assume that the data at the nodes other than x_i are unisolvent on Π_m by themselves. Let $q \in Q_i$ satisfy (i), with $\deg q = \alpha$ and $\Delta^{\alpha/2} q \ne 0$. Then, for every choice of the data at x_i, the datum q is reproduced only if the data at the other nodes lie in a fixed affine hyperplane.*

Proof. By (i) the middle term of (7) vanishes, and $\Delta^{\alpha/2} q = c$ is a non-zero constant, so the error is $c\,\tau(x_i) = c\,\sigma(x_i)(x_i) = c\,s_0(x_i)$ with s_0 from the proof of Theorem 4.1. The error is an affine function of the data at the other nodes (with y_i fixed); it vanishes for the data $y_j = \Lambda_j p_i^*$, so it suffices to exhibit data for which it does not.

Since $\deg q = \alpha \geq 2$, some derivative $\partial^\gamma q$ with $|\gamma| = \alpha$ is a non-zero constant, so $1 \in Q_i$ by (i): point evaluation $\ell(p) = p(x_i)$ is a datum at x_i. It vanishes on N_i and is non-zero on Π_m, hence non-zero on R.

Choose $y_j = \Lambda_j(p_i^* + v)$, $j \neq i$, for some $v \in \Pi_m$. Then $B_{x_i}(p) = \langle K(p - p_i^* - v), p - p_i^* - v\rangle$ with $K = \sum_{j\neq i} \frac{w_j(x_i)}{\rho_i(x_i)} \Lambda_j^* \Lambda_j$, which is positive definite on Π_m by the additional assumption. The minimiser n_0 over N_i is characterised by $K(n_0 - v) \perp N_i$, i.e. $K(n_0 - v) \in R$, so $\nabla_R B_{x_i}(p_i^* + n_0) = 2K(n_0 - v)$ and $s_0 = (L^*L)^{-1}Kw$ with $w = v - n_0$. As v ranges over Π_m, w ranges over the K-orthogonal complement $W = \{w : Kw \in R\}$ of N_i, so Kw ranges over all of R and s_0 over all of R. Choosing v with $\ell(s_0) \neq 0$ completes the proof. □

Corollary 4.7 (Sharpness)**.** *Under the hypotheses of Proposition 4.6 on the other nodes, let x_i carry classical Hermite data of order $k \leq m$. If $\alpha \leq k$, the datum $\partial_1^\alpha f(x_i)$ is not reproduced for data at the other nodes outside an affine hyperplane. Hence $\alpha > k$ is the exact condition for all Hermite data of order k to be reproduced for all data values.*

Proof. $q = \xi_1^\alpha \in Q_i$ satisfies (i) by D-invariance, $\deg q = \alpha$ and $\Delta^{\alpha/2}\xi_1^\alpha = \alpha! \neq 0$. □

4.4. **The role of condition (i).** When (i) fails, the middle term of (7) involves derivatives of ν, which are governed by how the weights of the *other* nodes vary near x_i. Two situations can be described completely.

Theorem 4.8 (Frozen minimiser)**.** *Let Assumption 3.5 hold and suppose that the frozen minimiser Z of (6) is constant near x_i. Then every $q \in Q_i$ with $\deg q \leq \alpha$ satisfies*

$$\big[q, u\big]_{x_i} - y_q = \big[\Delta^{\alpha/2} q, \partial_t n(x_i, 0) + \tau\big]_{x_i}, \tag{9}$$

where $\Delta^{\alpha/2} q$ is a constant. In particular every $q \in Q_i$ with $\deg q < \alpha$, or with $\deg q = \alpha$ and $\Delta^{\alpha/2} q = 0$, is reproduced, whether or not (i) holds.

Proof. By Theorem 4.1, $\nu(x) = n(x, t(x))$ with $n(x, 0) = Z(x)$ constant, so $\nu(x) = Z(x_i) + t(x)\, g(x)$ with $g(x) = \int_0^1 \partial_t n(x, \theta t(x))\, d\theta$ smooth and $g(x_i) = \partial_t n(x_i, 0)$. Since t vanishes at x_i to order α, $D^\gamma[t\, g](x_i) = 0$ for $|\gamma| < \alpha$ and $D^\gamma[t\, g](x_i) = (D^\gamma t)(x_i)\, g(x_i)$ for $|\gamma| = \alpha$. In the middle term of (7): the $\gamma = 0$ term is $\big[q, \nu(x_i)\big]_{x_i} = 0$ because $q \in Q_i$ and $\nu(x_i) \in N_i$; the terms with $0 < |\gamma| < \alpha$ vanish because the constant $Z(x_i)$ is killed by D^γ and $t\, g$ has vanishing derivatives of these orders; the terms with $|\gamma| > \alpha$ vanish because $\partial^\gamma q = 0$; and the terms with $|\gamma| = \alpha$, in which $\partial^\gamma q$ is a constant, add up by Lemma 3.4 to

$$\sum_{|\gamma|=\alpha} \frac{1}{\gamma!} (D^\gamma t)(x_i) \big[\partial^\gamma q, g(x_i)\big]_{x_i} = \big[\Delta^{\alpha/2} q, \partial_t n(x_i, 0)\big]_{x_i}.$$

Together with $\big[q, p_i^*\big]_{x_i} = y_q$ and the last term of (7) this gives (9). □

Corollary 4.9. *The frozen minimiser is constant near x_i, and hence Theorem 4.8 applies, in each of the following cases:*

- *(a)* single scale: *$w_j(x)/\rho_i(x) = c(x)\kappa_j$ near x_i for all $j \neq i$, with a positive function c and constants $\kappa_j > 0$; this includes the case of a single other node ($K = 2$) and weights whose germs at x_i are proportional;*
- *(b)* interpolatory restriction: *the functionals $\lambda_{j,s}$, $j \neq i$, that do not vanish identically on N_i restrict to a basis of the dual of N_i (so that the frozen problem can fit them exactly whatever the weights).*

Proof. (a) $B_x = c(x)\hat{B}$ with $\hat{B}$ independent of x, and the minimiser of $c(x)\hat{B}$ over $p_i^* + N_i$ does not depend on $c(x) > 0$. (b) The frozen objective is a positively weighted sum of squared residuals of functionals that are either constant on $p_i^* + N_i$ or, by assumption, can be made zero simultaneously by exactly one $n \in N_i$, which is then the minimiser for every choice of positive weights. □

Example 4.10. These cases are not exotic: for two nodes, gradient data at x_i without a function value are reproduced for $\alpha \geq 2$; in one dimension with $m = 1$, the data $f'(0)$, $f(1)$, $f'(5/2)$ are all reproduced (case (b): only $f(1)$ sees the constants, which form N_i at the slope nodes). A third node in the first case, or a further value datum in the second, destroys the structure, and the data are then no longer reproduced (Section 7).

In general the frozen minimiser moves, and a failure of (i) at first order produces an explicit error.

Proposition 4.11 (First-order error)**.** *Let Assumption 3.5 hold and let $q \in Q_i$ with $\deg q < \alpha$, such that $\partial^\gamma q \in Q_i$ for all $|\gamma| \geq 2$. Then*

$$[q,u]_{x_i} - y_q = \sum_{j=1}^{d} \big[\partial_j q, \partial_{x_j} Z(x_i)\big]_{x_i}, \qquad \partial_{x_j} Z(x_i) = -H^{-1}\, \partial_{x_j}\big[\nabla_N B_x\big](p_i^* + Z(x_i))\Big|_{x=x_i}, \tag{10}$$

where H is the Hessian of B_{x_i} restricted to N_i.

Proof. In (7) the last term vanishes because $\deg q < \alpha$, and the middle terms with $\gamma = 0$ or $|\gamma| \geq 2$ vanish as in Corollary 4.4. For $|\gamma| = 1$, $D_j\big[\partial_j q, \nu(x)\big]_{x_i} = \big[\partial_j q, \partial_{x_j}\nu(x_i)\big]_{x_i}$ and $\partial_{x_j}\nu(x_i) = \partial_{x_j} n(x_i, 0) + \partial_t n(x_i, 0)\, \partial_j t(x_i) = \partial_{x_j} Z(x_i)$ since $\alpha \geq 2$. Differentiating $\nabla_N B_x(p_i^* + Z(x)) = 0$ gives the formula for $\partial_{x_j} Z$. □

The right-hand side of (10) is an explicit linear functional of the data; for pure power weights ($\rho \equiv 1$) it is a rational function of the node positions. It vanishes in the cases of Corollary 4.9 and for symmetric configurations (e.g. $\partial_{x_1} w_j(x_i) = 0$ for all j), but it is non-zero in the explicit examples of Section 5, and therefore, by analyticity, for node positions in an open dense set for those data patterns.

Conjecture 4.12. *Let $\rho \equiv 1$, let Q_i be D-invariant and the other nodes unisolvent by themselves. If $\Delta^{\alpha/2} q \neq 0$ then, for node positions outside a proper algebraic subset, q is not reproduced for data outside a hyperplane.*

Remark 4.13. Proposition 4.6 proves the conjecture for $\deg q = \alpha$. It is supported by the experiments of Section 7 (e.g. $\partial_x^2 \partial_y f$ at $\alpha = 2$ fails even for $K = 2$). Characterising the node configurations for which a failure of (i) causes an error, beyond the first-order formula (10), is open.

5. Derivative data without function values

5.1. **Counterexamples.** Komargodski and Levin [8, §3] extend their Hermite MLS, with weights $|x - z|^{-\alpha}$, $\alpha \in 2\mathbb{N}$, and local spaces containing the constants and the linear functions, to directional derivatives prescribed at points that need not carry function values, and state that the derivative data are interpolated, the proof being "straightforward ... by slight modifications" of the co-located case. Condition (i) fails for such data: the symbol of a first derivative differentiates to the constant 1, which is not in Q_i when no value is prescribed at the node. By Theorem 4.8 this does not always cause an error, but it can, and does in the following examples, computed in exact rational arithmetic (scripts in `code/proofs`).

Proposition 5.1. *Let $d = 1$, $m = 1$ (local polynomials $a + by$), $\alpha = 2$, $\rho_i \equiv 1$, and prescribe $f(0) = f(2) = 0$ and $f'(1) = f'(3) = 1$. Then*

$$u(x) = \frac{x\,(x-1)(x-2)\,(x^2-4x+5)}{2x^4-14x^3+37x^2-42x+19},$$

which satisfies $u(0) = u(2) = 0$ but $u'(1) = -1$ and $u'(3) = 31/25$.

Proof. With $w_z(x) = (x-z)^{-2}$ the normal equations of (4) for (a, b) are

$$\begin{pmatrix} w_0+w_2 & 2w_2 \\ 2w_2 & 4w_2+w_1+w_3 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} a \\ b \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ w_1+w_3 \end{pmatrix},$$

whose solution gives $u = a + bx$ as stated; the denominator has no real zeros. The remaining values follow by direct computation. □

Proposition 5.2. *Let $d = 2$, $m = 1$, $\alpha = 2$, $\rho_i \equiv 1$, and prescribe $f = 0$ at $(0,0)$, $(2,0)$, $(0,2)$ and $\nabla f(1,1) = (1,1)$. With $s = x_1 + x_2$, $r = x_1^2 + x_2^2$ and $p = x_1 x_2$,*

$$u = \frac{15sr^2 - 68r^2 - 64pr + 128sr + 16ps - 128r - 96p + 48s}{35r^2 - 120sr + 240r + 208p - 240s + 144},$$

which vanishes at the three value points, while $\nabla u(1,1) = (5/9, 5/9)$.

Proof. Exact computation as in Proposition 5.1, with three unknowns (script in `code/proofs`). The denominator tends to $+\infty$ as $|x| \to \infty$, and its minimum, attained on the diagonal near $(0.898, 0.898)$, is $11.21\ldots > 0$. □

The failure persists for $\alpha = 4$ and for $m = 2$ (Section 7).

5.2. **Completion.** Given data at x_i with symbol space Q_i, let $\overline{Q}_i$ be the smallest D-invariant space containing Q_i; it has the same maximal degree as Q_i, since differentiation lowers degrees. Choose a basis $\tilde{q}_{i,1}, \ldots, \tilde{q}_{i,r}$ of a complement of Q_i in $\overline{Q}_i$.

Proposition 5.3 (Completion)**.** *Augment the data at x_i by the functionals $\tilde{q}_{i,l}(D)f(x_i)$ with arbitrary values $\tilde{y}_{i,l}$. If Assumption 3.5 holds for the original data, it holds for the augmented data, and every original datum $q \in Q_i$ with $\Delta^{\alpha/2} q = 0$ (in particular every datum of order less than α) is reproduced by the augmented interpolant, whatever the values $\tilde{y}_{i,l}$.*

Proof. The augmented symbols at x_i form a basis of $\overline{Q}_i$, so (A2) holds; (A3) is preserved by adding data. The prescribed value y_q of an original datum is unchanged, because its representation in the augmented basis is unique. Every $q \in Q_i \subset \overline{Q}_i$ satisfies (i) with respect to the D-invariant space $\overline{Q}_i$, and Corollary 4.4 applies. □

The values $\tilde{y}_{i,l}$ influence the accuracy, not the exactness. In the experiments they are estimated by a smooth (non-singular) moving least-squares fit of the given data.

6. Numerical evaluation

The usual implementation of interpolating MLS replaces $|x - x_i|^{-\alpha}$ by $(|x - x_i|^\alpha + \varepsilon)^{-1}$ and solves the normal equations. This gives up exactness at the nodes and, near a node, squares a condition number that grows like $|x - x_i|^{-\alpha}$. Our evaluator avoids both problems. All of it is in the accompanying code.

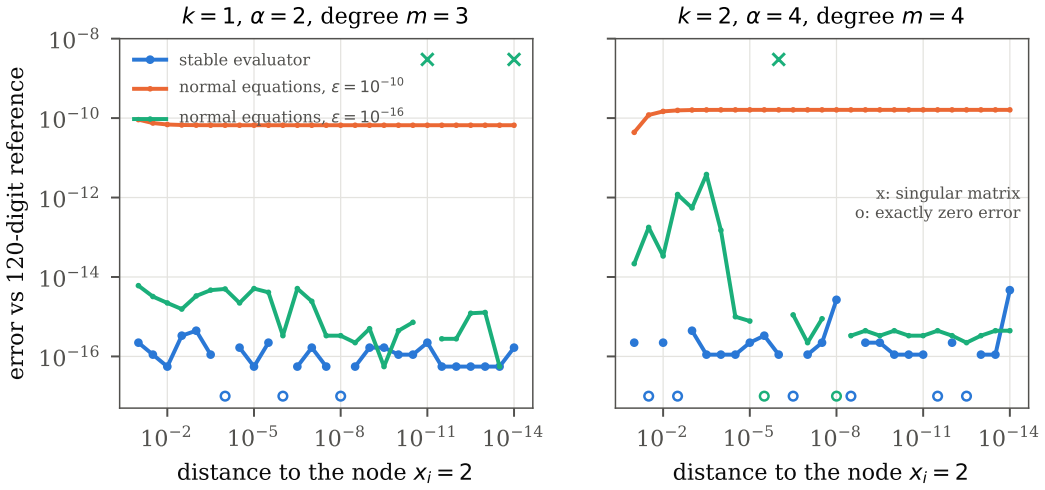


FIGURE 2. Error of the evaluation near the node $x_i = 2$ (nodes $1, 2, 3, 4$ with Hermite data of order k and random values), against a 120-digit reference. Crosses mark singular normal equations, open circles errors that are exactly zero.

Basis and weights. At the evaluation point x we use the monomials $((y-x)/h)^\beta$, $|\beta| \le m$, with a length scale h, so that $u(x)$ is the first coefficient. In the experiments the weights are $w_i(x) = |x - x_i|^{-\alpha} e^{-|x-x_i|^2/\delta^2}$, which satisfy (A1); they are computed as logarithms and normalised by their maximum, and nodes whose normalised weight is below a cutoff are dropped. The cutoff is measured relative to the strongest node *other than* the nearest one; measured relative to the nearest node, it would drop all other nodes close to a node and destroy the information that fixes ν. Rows of derivative data of order r are multiplied by ℓ^r for a length ℓ; by the remark after Definition 3.6 this does not affect the results of Section 4.

Least squares. The weighted system $W^{1/2} A\, a \approx W^{1/2} b$ is solved by an SVD-based least-squares solver rather than through the normal equations. Close to a node x_i the rows of x_i dominate the others by a factor s^{-1} with $s \sim |x - x_i|^{\alpha/2}$, and once s^2 is below the machine precision a standard solver ignores the light rows, i.e. it loses $\nu(x)$. When $s < 10^{-3}$ we therefore solve an exact reformulation. Let R and L be the heavy and light rows, Q_1 and Q_2 orthonormal bases of the row space and the null space of R, and c_0 the least-squares solution of $RQ_1 c = b_R$. Writing $a = Q_1(c_0 + s\,d) + Q_2 z$ and dividing the objective by s^2 gives the problem

$$\min_{d,z} \ \|RQ_1 d\|^2 + \left\|LQ_1 d + s^{-1} LQ_2 z - s^{-1}(b_L - LQ_1 c_0)\right\|^2,$$

whose blocks are well scaled; it has the same minimiser and is the discrete counterpart of the decomposition (5).

At the nodes. At $x = x_i$ we use the limit of Theorem 4.1: the data at x_i are imposed as equality constraints, and the remaining freedom in N_i is fixed by minimising the frozen functional (6); then $u(x_i) = (p_i^* + Z(x_i))(x_i)$.

Accuracy. Figure 2 compares the evaluator with a reference computed with 120 significant digits, as the evaluation point approaches a node. Its error stays at the level of rounding (below $5 \cdot 10^{-15}$) down to distance 10^{-14}, With $\varepsilon = 10^{-10}$ the regularised normal equations have errors up to $1.6 \cdot 10^{-10}$, the size of the regularisation; with $\varepsilon = 10^{-16}$ the errors reach $4 \cdot 10^{-12}$ and the matrix is numerically singular at some distances.

Verifying exactness. The experiments below decide whether a datum q is reproduced by computing $\big[q,u\big]_{x_i}$ in high-precision arithmetic (`mpmath`). The interpolant is evaluated from the normal equations at a working precision of $40+(2\alpha+|\beta|+5)\,|\log_{10} r|$ digits, and derivatives are taken with tensor-product Chebyshev stencils of radius r that are exact for polynomials of degree $|\beta|+5$ in each variable and never sample the node itself. A datum is called reproduced if $|\big[q,u\big]_{x_i}-y_q|\le 10^{-12}\max(1,|y_q|)$ for both $r=10^{-6}$ and $r=10^{-4}$, and not reproduced if the inequality fails for both. Mixed outcomes never occurred. In all reproduced cases the error scales like the stencil error r^6 (about 10^{-30} and 10^{-20}), while in the others it is the same at both radii to the digits shown.

7. Numerical experiments

All experiments use the evaluator and the verification procedure of Section 6; scripts, logs and data are in the accompanying repository. Unless stated otherwise, nodes are random, the data values are random numbers (exactness does not depend on them being samples of a function), and every node other than the one under study carries Hermite data, so that the generic situation of Section 4 applies.

7.1. **Hermite data.** We checked every datum at one node for classical Hermite data of order k in one, two and three dimensions: $(d,k,\alpha)=(1,5,4)$, $(1,7,6)$, $(2,2,2)$, $(2,3,2)$, $(2,3,4)$, $(2,4,4)$, $(3,2,2)$ and $(3,3,2)$, with $m=k+1$ or $k+2$; and a two-dimensional node carrying the D-invariant space of harmonic symbols of degree at most 3 (1, ξ_1, ξ_2, $\xi_1\xi_2$, $\xi_1^2-\xi_2^2$, $\xi_1^3-3\xi_1\xi_2^2$, $3\xi_1^2\xi_2-\xi_2^3$) at $\alpha=2$. In all 92 data, the datum is reproduced exactly when $\Delta^{\alpha/2}q=0$ and is not reproduced otherwise, as Corollary 4.5 and Conjecture 4.12 predict. For instance, at $\alpha=2$ in three dimensions, $\partial_x\partial_y\partial_z f$ is reproduced while $\partial_x^2 f$ has error 30.

At a node with Hermite data of order 3 in two dimensions and $\alpha=2$, the signed errors satisfy the identities that follow from (8), namely $e(\partial_x^2)=e(\partial_y^2)=-45.904682196$, $e(\partial_x^3)=3e(\partial_x\partial_y^2)=599.09999304$ and $e(\partial_y^3)=3e(\partial_x^2\partial_y)=-31.441788804$, to all twelve digits computed, while $f,\partial_x f,\partial_y f,\partial_x\partial_y f$ are reproduced.

7.2. **Hermite–Birkhoff data.** Next one node carries a pattern with gaps: in one dimension the orders $\{0,2\}$, $\{0,3\}$, $\{1\}$, $\{2\}$, $\{1,2\}$, $\{0,1,3\}$ and $\{0,2,3\}$ (and two complete patterns), with $\alpha=8$, $m=5$; in two dimensions ten patterns such as $\{f,\partial_{xx}\}$, $\{f,\partial_x,\partial_{xy}\}$, $\{f,\Delta\}$, $\{\partial_x\}$ and a directional derivative, with $\alpha=6$, $m=3$, and four patterns at $\alpha=2$. Since α exceeds the order of the data in the first two groups, condition (ii) holds there, and only (i) decides. In all 83 data the outcome agrees with conditions (i) and (ii): for example $\partial_{xy}f$ is not reproduced in the pattern $\{f,\partial_x,\partial_{xy}\}$, because its derivative ξ_2 is missing, and the Laplacian is not reproduced in $\{f,\Delta\}$.

7.3. **Configurations of Theorem 4.8.** Condition (i) fails in each of the following configurations, and yet the data are reproduced, as Theorem 4.8 and Proposition 4.11 predict. Each configuration is followed by a small perturbation that destroys the special structure, after which the datum is no longer reproduced (two random data vectors each).

configuration	datum	reason	error
1D: $f'(0)$, $f(1)$, $f'(5/2)$; $m=1$, $\alpha=2$	f' at 0, 5/2	Cor. 4.9(b)	$< 10^{-36}$
add $f(4)$			0.21–2.1
2D, $K=2$: $\nabla f(x_1)$; $f, \nabla f, \nabla^2 f$ at x_2; $m=2$, $\alpha=2$	∂_x, ∂_y	Cor. 4.9(a)	$< 10^{-31}$
add a third node			0.03–0.46
2D, $K=2$: $f, \partial_{xx} f$ at x_1; Hermite $k=2$ at x_2; $\alpha=4$	∂_{xx}	Cor. 4.9(a)	$< 10^{-21}$
add a third node			2.9–3.3
2D: $\partial_x f(0)$; others on the x_2-axis; $m=1$, $\alpha=2$	∂_x	Prop. 4.11	$< 10^{-29}$
move the others by 0.05			0.08–0.16

In the symmetric configuration the weights of the other nodes are even in x_1, so $\partial_{x_1} Z(x_i) = 0$ and the right-hand side of (10) vanishes for $q = \xi_1$. The experiments in the previous subsection avoid such configurations by using random node positions.

7.4. **Derivatives at points without values.** In the setting of [8, §3]: eight random points carry values and eight other points carry gradients, the weights are $|x - x_i|^{-\alpha}$ and the local space is Π_1 or Π_2. For all four combinations of $m \in \{1, 2\}$ and $\alpha \in \{2, 4\}$ the values are reproduced, but none of the 24 gradient components checked (three gradient points) is: the errors lie between 0.06 and 4.5. After completion (Proposition 5.3; checked for $m = 2$, $\alpha = 2$ with a Gaussian factor in the weights), all of them are reproduced. Completion also repairs every non-reproduced datum of the previous Birkhoff patterns of order less than α: 19 of 19.

Completion does cost accuracy. With values at n Halton points and gradients at n others for Franke's function ($m = 3$, $\alpha = 2$), the maximum error on $[0.1, 0.9]^2$ for $n = 1024$ is $1.2 \cdot 10^{-3}$ without and $3.4 \cdot 10^{-3}$ with completion. In exchange, the mismatch of the gradients drops from $4.4 \cdot 10^{-2}$ to the level of the finite differences used to measure it. The added values were estimated by a simple Gaussian-weighted least-squares fit; better estimators would reduce the penalty.

7.5. **Convergence.** We do not prove convergence orders, and report what a parameter study shows. The nodes are the first $N = 64, \dots, 4096$ points of the Halton sequence in $[0, 1]^2$, the data are values (and gradients, and Hessians) of $f(x, y) = e^{x+y/2} \cos 2y + \sin 3xy$, the weights carry a Gaussian factor of width $\delta = ch$ with $h = N^{-1/2}$, and errors are measured on a 33×33 grid in $[0.1, 0.9]^2$. We varied $c \in \{1.5, 2, 3, 4\}$ ($c \in \{2, 3, 4, 5\}$ for values with $m \geq 4$), the data order $k \in \{0, 1, 2\}$, the degree $m \in \{2, \dots, 5\}$ and $\alpha \in \{2, 4\}$ with $\alpha > k$, in 44 combinations.

- *Rates.* Over the last three refinements, the root-mean-square error decays like h^r with $|r - (m+1)| \leq 0.53$ in every combination, i.e. at the rate known for MLS approximation with local degree m [10, 22]. The maximum error is less regular, with rates between $m - 0.3$ and $m + 1.6$. The rate depends on m, not on k or α.
- *Width.* At $N = 4096$ the narrowest Gaussian tried ($c = 1.5$, or $c = 2$ where 1.5 was not run) gives the smallest error in every case; wider ones cost a factor between 2.6 and 54 in the error, not in the rate.
- *Hermite data.* On a fixed node set, derivative data reduce the error (Figure 3(a)): for $N = 4096$ and $m = 5$ from $5.0 \cdot 10^{-9}$ (values) to $1.1 \cdot 10^{-9}$ (values, gradients and Hessians). Per number of data, however, values alone were more accurate in this experiment (Figure 3(b)). Derivative data pay off when nodes are expensive and derivatives are cheap, as with adjoint gradients, rather than per datum.

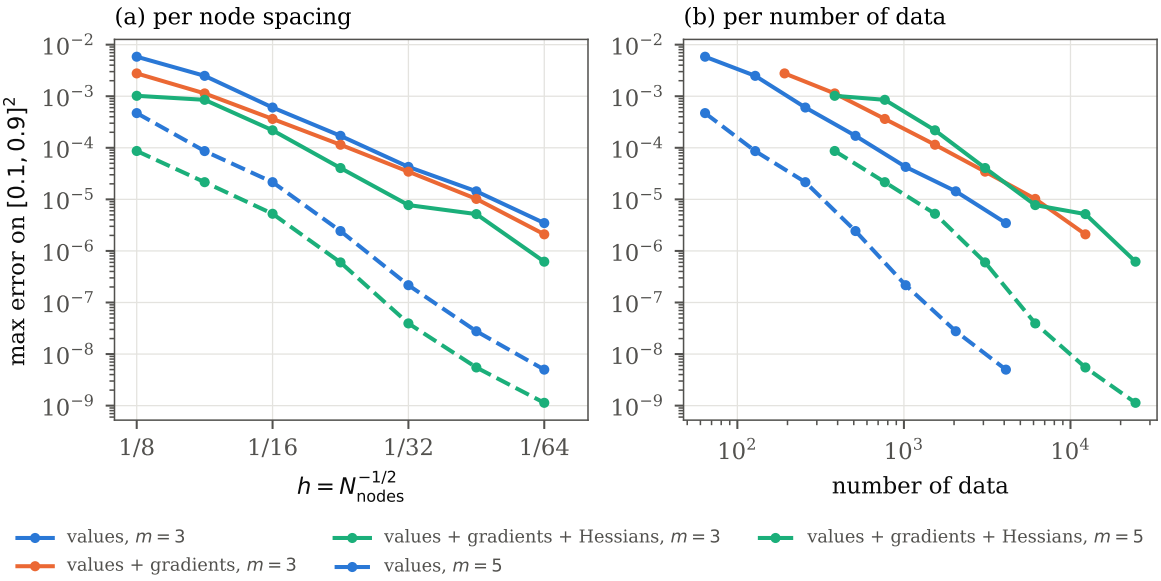


FIGURE 3. Maximum error on $[0.1, 0.9]^2$ for Halton nodes, $\delta = 2h$; $\alpha = 2$ except for Hessian data ($\alpha = 4$). (a) Against the node spacing. (b) Against the total number of data.

8. Conclusions

Singular-weight moving least squares extends from function values to arbitrary linear differential data with no change to its definition: one weighted least-squares problem per evaluation point, with no mesh, no global system and no poisedness condition beyond unisolvency of all the data on the local polynomial space. The interpolant is C^∞, and Theorem 4.3 accounts exactly for the error in every datum. Two mechanisms can spoil a datum: the singularity of the weight, which acts through $\Delta^{\alpha/2}$, and the motion of the frozen minimiser, which acts only on data whose derivatives are missing at their node. The first is removed by choosing α larger than the order of the data, the second by completing the data at the node. Together they give a simple recipe for Hermite–Birkhoff interpolation of any order in any dimension.

Several questions remain open. Conjecture 4.12 asks whether $\Delta^{\alpha/2} q \neq 0$ always causes an error in generic configurations; we proved it at leading order. Beyond the first-order formula (10), we do not know exactly which configurations of the other nodes make condition (i) unnecessary. The convergence orders observed in Section 7.5 call for an error analysis in the spirit of [10, 22] that accounts for derivative data and singular weights. Finally, the values added by completion affect the accuracy, not the exactness, and better ways of estimating them would reduce the accuracy penalty observed in Section 7.

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